

Fall 2025

Sociology 308S - Health and Society
T/TH 6:00-8:00pm

Instructors

Asya Saydam & Charlotte Perez

Welcome!

Hello everyone, and *welcome to Health and Society!*

You all bring valuable experiences to the table, and in this class, your ideas matter. We'll examine how health and illness are not just medical but deeply social issues, shaped by social class, race, gender, immigration, policy, and history. Be ready to have your perspectives challenged and expanded. Topics might feel heavy sometimes, such as health disparities, structural and sexual violence, the pandemic, stigma, death, but please remember you are not alone in this space. If any material becomes overwhelming, let us know, and we'll find a way to support you.

Course Description

Health often seems personal. When you visit a doctor, they usually ask about your individual choices – what you eat, how much you exercise, whether you smoke or drink. However, our health is also shaped by much bigger forces. For example, what we eat depends not just on our choices, but also on our income, how much time we have, and whether there's a grocery store nearby.

We'll explore how structures of power, inequality, and policy decisions shape health outcomes and access to care. Students will learn about sociological and demographic theories of health and illness, as well as the structure of the US health system. Together, we'll build tools to develop a sociologically informed perspective on disparities in health and illness across gender, sexuality, race and ethnicity, and social class. Our goal is to help you think critically about the big picture behind health and how we might work toward a more just and healthy society. *This syllabus is subject to change with fair notice.*

Course objectives

By the end of this class, you will be able to:

1. Understand how health and illness are shaped by broader social structures.
2. Identify how race, class, gender, and migration status influence health outcomes in the U.S.
3. Analyze health disparities using sociological concepts.
4. Connect personal experiences and social forces using the sociological imagination.
5. Synthesizing readings, draw connections between texts, and develop arguments that are supported by evidence

Class Format

The class format will consist of both lectures and discussion sections. *Students are expected to come to each class having read the materials, completed assignments, ready to take notes, and prepared to actively participate in class discussion.*

Grading

Your grade will be based on the following:

1) *Introductory survey (1% of final grade)*

2) *Midterm exam (25% of final grade)*

The midterm exam will take place in class on October 14. This exam will consist of 20 multiple choice questions and 4 short answer questions based on content from class.

3) *Weekly memos (25% of final grade)*

Students will complete a total of six one-page memos throughout the semester in which they reflect and respond to the readings. Memos are a space where students can draw connections between readings, identify themes, and generate questions about the relationship between social structures and health.

Students can select any six weeks out of nine to write their memos. Prompts will be distributed at the conclusion of lecture on a topic and will be due at the start of lecture the following week (e.g., memos for week 2 will be due at the beginning of lecture in week 3) – except week 1. Memos will be graded for completion.

4) *Health profile exercise (15% of final grade)*

Students will be given two patient case studies and asked to develop three sociologically-informed questions that they believe a health care provider should ask of each patient. For each question, students should provide a 3-5 sentence rationale for the social and health relevance of the question that they would pose to this patient. Profiles will be distributed on October 21st and students' responses will be due on November 4.

5) *Final essay (25% of final grade)*

At the end of the semester, students will have an opportunity to synthesize their learnings and demonstrate that they can think sociologically about health through a final essay. Students will receive prompts for their final essay on November 6th; final essays will be due on December 4.

6) *Class participation (8% of final grade)*

We will all learn the most from this course by showing up for class prepared to discuss the readings and willing to engage with each other. We encourage everyone to practice *lean in/lean out*. If speaking up feels challenging, try leaning in by contributing occasionally. If you're someone who is always excited to speak, practice leaning out sometimes to make space for others. Together, we'll build a balanced and inclusive discussion environment. *Bonus: Community point (for contributing to the shared learning space) (1% of final grade)*

Grading Scale

This class employs a plus/minus grading system. Below is the grade scale the University employs and which will be used in this class:

Meets class requirement		Does not meet requirement	
Grade	Points	Grade	Points
A	≥93.00	C-	70.00-72.99
A-	90.00-92.99	D+	67.00-69.99
B+	87.00-89.99	D	63.00-66.99
B	83.00-86.99	D-	60.00-62.99
B-	80.00-82.99	F	<60.00
C+	77.00-79.99		
C	73.00-76.99		

Readings

All readings are available in the course reader, which will be handed out on the first week of class. There can be additional readings which will be handed out during class. *You are expected to have completed each week's readings before class.*

Academic Honesty

All students are expected to abide by the UT Honor Code/University Code of Conduct: "As a student of The University of Texas at Austin, I shall abide by the core values of the University and uphold academic integrity." At a minimum, students should complete any assignments, exams, and other scholastic endeavors with the utmost honesty, which requires you to:

1. Acknowledge the contributions of other sources to your scholastic work
2. Complete your assignments independently unless specifically allowed to collaborate with others
3. Follow instructions for assignments and exams and observe the standards of your academic discipline
4. Verify what sources can be used to complete assignments or accessed during quizzes and tests.

All of your work must be your own. You must make sure you cite your sources if you are using ideas that are not original to you, or else you are plagiarizing. Plagiarism is taken very seriously, and if you plagiarize you will be subject to academic disciplinary action, including potential failure of the course. Please talk to your professor if you have questions about plagiarism.

Late policy

Unless otherwise stated, assignments are due at the start of class. Late memos will not be accepted. All other assignments will be penalized by 10 points per class period that they are late. Please talk with your instructors if you anticipate difficulty meeting deadlines.

Fall 2025

Course Schedule

This course will be broken into three units:

- 1) Introduction and background to understanding health and society
- 2) Social theory for understanding health
- 3) Disparities in health and illness

Key Dates:

October 14 - Midterm exam in class

November 4 - Health profile assignment due

December 4 - Final essay due

Week	Date	Topic	Readings	Op-ed, Newsletter Readings	Assignments etc.
Unit 1: Introduction and background to understanding health and society					
1	9/2	Introduction; syllabus review; guidance on academic writing; tips for reading a scientific article			* Introductory survey (distributed and collected in class)
	9/4	Lecture: Social Frameworks for Thinking About Health	* Copelton, Denise A., and Gregory L. Weiss. 2023. "A Brief Introduction to the Sociology of Health, Healing, and Illness." in <i>The Sociology of Health, Healing, and Illness</i>. Routledge. * Jones, Podolsky, and Greene. 2012. "The Burden of Disease and the Changing Task of Medicine." <i>The New England Journal of Medicine</i> 366(25): 2333-2338. * Johnson, Allan G. 2014. <i>The Forest and the Trees: Sociology as Life, Practice, and Promise</i> 3rd Ed. Philadelphia: Temple University Press.		* Weekly Memo #1 distributed

2	9/9	Lecture: Social Epidemiology and U.S. Trends in Context	* Copelton, Denise A., and Gregory L. Weiss. 2023. "Social Epidemiology." in <i>The Sociology of Health, Healing, and Illness</i>. Routledge. * Crimmins, Eileen M., and Yuan S. Zhang. 2019. "Aging Populations, Mortality, and Life Expectancy." <i>Annual Review of Sociology</i> 45 (Volume 45, 2019):69–89.	* Murphy, Terry. 2024. "Seem like Peanut Allergies Were Once Rare and Now Everyone Has Them?"	* Weekly Memo #1 collected (at the beginning) * Weekly Memo #2 distributed (at the end)
	9/11	Discussion: Social Frameworks to think about health, Social Epidemiology and U.S. Trends			
3	9/16	Lecture: Social Construction of Disease and Medicalization	* Moynihan. 2003. "The Making of a Disease: Female Sexual Dysfunction." <i>British Medical Journal</i> 326:45-47. * Armstrong, Elizabeth M. 2003. <i>Conceiving Risk, Bearing Responsibility: Fetal Alcohol Syndrome & the Diagnosis of Moral Disorder</i>. Pp. 1-22, 106-128. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press. * Gutin, Iliya. 2018. "In BMI We Trust: Reframing the Body Mass Index as a Measure of Health." <i>Social Theory & Health</i>: STH 16(3):256–71.	* Pollack, Andrew. 2015. "F.D.A. Approves Addyi, a Libido Pill for Women." <i>The New York Times</i>, August 18. * Brown, Harriet. 2015. "How Obesity Became a Disease." <i>The Atlantic</i>. March 24, 2015.	* Weekly Memo#2 collected * Weekly Memo #3 distributed
	9/18	Discussion: Medicalization			
4	9/23	Lecture: Health System in the U.S. and the U.S. Health Disadvantage	* Copelton, Denise A., and Gregory L. Weiss. 2023. "The United States Health Care System." in <i>The Sociology of Health, Healing, and Illness</i>. Routledge. * Avendano and Kawachi. 2014. "Why do Americans have Shorter Life Expectancy and Worse Health Than Do People in Other High-Income Countries?" <i>Annual Review of Public Health</i> 35:307-25.	* Tavernise, Sabrina. 2013. "The Health Toll of Immigration." <i>The New York Times</i> , May 18.	* Weekly Memo #3 collected * Weekly Memo #4 distributed
	9/25	Discussion: The US. Health System and the disadvantage			

Unit 2: Social theory for understanding health					
5	9/30	Lecture: Social Determinants of Health	* Link, B. G., and J. Phelan. 1995. "Social Conditions as Fundamental Causes of Disease." <i>Journal of Health and Social Behavior</i> Spec No:80–94. * Ratcliff, Kathryn Strother. 2017. "The Social Determinants of Health." in <i>The Social Determinants of Health: Looking Upstream</i>. Cambridge, UK: Polity. * Heath, Dan. 2020. "Moving Upstream." in <i>Upstream: The Quest to Solve Problems Before They Happen</i>. New York: Avid Reader Press / Simon & Schuster. (optional)	* Scott, Janny. 2005. "Life at the Top in America Isn't Just Better, It's Longer." New York Times, May 16.	* Weekly Memo #4 collected * Weekly Memo #5 distributed
	10/2	Discussion: Social Causes of Health and Longevity - Upstream/Downstream Perspectives			
6	10/7	Lecture: Stress Process and Life Course	* Weiss, Gregory L., and Denise A. Copelton. 2020. "Social Stress." in <i>The Sociology of Health, Healing, and Illness</i>. Routledge. * Shonkoff, Jack P., Andrew S. Garner, Committee on Psychosocial Aspects of Child and Family Health, Committee on Early Childhood, Adoption, and Dependent Care, and Section on Developmental and Behavioral Pediatrics. 2012. "The Lifelong Effects of Early Childhood Adversity and Toxic Stress." <i>Pediatrics</i> 129(1):e232-246.	* Hurley, Dan. 2015. "Grandma's Experiences Leave a Mark on Your Genes." <i>Discover Magazine</i> , June 25.	* Weekly Memo #5 collected
	10/9	Discussion: Stress Process and Midterm review			
7	10/14	Midterm exam			
	10/16	Discussion: Go over the exam			

Unit 3: Disparities in Health and Illness					
8	10/21	Lecture: Socioeconomic Status and Health	* Ratcliff, Kathryn Strother. 2017. "Poverty and Health" in <i>The Social Determinants of Health: Looking Upstream</i>. Cambridge, UK: Polity. * Nosrati, Elias, Michael Ash, Michael Marmot, Martin McKee, and Lawrence P. King. 2018. "The Association between Income and Life Expectancy Revisited: Deindustrialization, Incarceration and the Widening Health Gap." <i>International Journal of Epidemiology</i> 47(3):720–30.	* Tavernise, Sabrina. 2016. "Disparity in Life Spans of the Rich and the Poor Is Growing." <i>The New York Times</i>, February 12. * Board, The Editorial. 2018. "Do Poor People Have a Right to Health Care?" <i>The New York Times</i>, July 7.	* Health profiles handed out (due 11/4) * Weekly Memo #6 distributed
	10/23	Discussion			
9	10/28	Lecture: Race/Ethnicity and Health	* Reskin, B. (2012). The Race Discrimination System. <i>Annual Review of Sociology</i>, 38, 17-35. * Williams, David R., and Michelle Sternthal. 2010. "Understanding Racial/Ethnic Disparities in Health: Sociological Contributions." <i>Journal of Health and Social Behavior</i> 51(Suppl):S15–27. * Jindal et al. 2022. Police Exposures and the Health and Well-being of Black Youth in the US: A Systematic Review. <i>JAMA Pediatrics</i>.	* Silverstein. 2013. "How Racism is Bad for Our Bodies." <i>The Atlantic</i>. * Kolata. 2018. "The Secret to Keeping Black Men Healthy? Maybe Black Doctors." <i>The New York Times</i>.	* Weekly Memo #6 collected * Weekly Memo #7 distributed
	10/30	Discussion: Race and Health; Health Profile Assignment Q&A			
10	11/4	Lecture: Gender, Sex & Health	* Courtenay. 2000. "Constructions of Masculinity and Their Influence on Men's Well-being: A Theory of Gender and Health." <i>Social Science & Medicine</i> 50:1385-1401. * Paine. 2018. "Embodied disruption: "Sorting out" Gender and Nonconformity in the Doctor's Office" <i>Social Science & Medicine</i> 211:352-358.	* Escalante, Alison. 2020. "Coronavirus Is Widening the Gender Gap for Working Mothers." <i>Forbes</i>.	* Weekly Memo #7 collected * Health profile assignment due

			* Homan, Patricia. 2019. "Structural Sexism and Health in the United States: A New Perspective on Health Inequality and the Gender System." <i>American Sociological Review</i> 84(3): 486-516. (optional)		* Weekly Memo #8 distributed
	11/6	Discussion: Gender and Health; Final Essay prompts explained			* Final essay prompts handed out (due 12/4)
11	11/11	Lecture: Social Relationships and Health	* Umberson, Debra, and Rachel Donnelly. 2023. "Social Isolation: An Unequally Distributed Health Hazard." <i>Annual Review of Sociology</i> 49 (Volume 49, 2023):379–99. * Saydam, Asya, Jaime Hsu and Michael Garcia. "Sleep Tight, Don't Fight? Daily Sleep and Marital Strain in Same- and Different-Sex Marriages in the United States". <i>Journal of Health and Social Behavior</i>. (under review)	* Staff Writer. 2023. "From Loneliness to Social Connection: Lessons from Research and a Global Pandemic." <i>Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health</i> .	* Weekly Memo #8 collected
	11/13	Discussion: Social Relationships and Health			
12	11/18	Lecture: Food, Health Crises, and the Social Body	* Puhl, Rebecca M., and Chelsea A. Heuer. 2010. "Obesity Stigma: Important Considerations for Public Health." <i>American Journal of Public Health</i> 100(6):1019–28. * Walker, Renee E., Christopher R. Keane, and Jessica G. Burke. 2010. "Disparities and Access to Healthy Food in the United States: A Review of Food Deserts Literature." <i>Health & Place</i> 16(5):876–84. * FRAC. 2015. <i>Understanding the Connections: Food</i>	* Bittman, Mark, Michael Pollan, Ricardo Salvador, and Olivier De Schutter. 2014. "How a National Food Policy Could Save Millions of American Lives." <i>The Washington Post</i> , November 7.	* Weekly Memo #9 distributed

			<i>Insecurity and Obesity</i> . Food Research and Action Center.		
	11/20	Discussion: Food, Place and Health & Final Essay Workshop			
13	11/25	Thanksgiving week - no class			
	11/27	Thanksgiving week - no class			
14	12/2	Lecture: Mental Health	* Thoits, Peggy A. 2017. "Sociological Approaches to Mental Illness." Pp. 126-144 in <i>A Handbook for the Study of Mental Health: Social Contexts, Theories, and Systems, Third Edition</i>, edited by T.L. Scheid and E. R. Wright. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. * Horwitz, Allan V. 2011. "Creating an Age of Depression: The Social Construction and Consequences of the Major Depression Diagnosis." <i>Society and Mental Health</i> 1(1):41–54.	* Ford, Matt. 2015. "America's Largest Mental Hospital Is a Jail." <i>The Atlantic</i> , June 8.	* Weekly Memo #9 collected
	12/4	Discussion & Wrap-Up			* Final essay due